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# 1. Introduction

## 1.1 Background of the Research

A new hotel selection tactic has emerged as online customer reviews, which serve as a type of electronic word of mouth. The travellers face written experiences, photographs, numerical ratings and scores when comparing accommodation (Saha and Biswas, 2025). These signals can help to minimise uncertainty around service quality but they must be credible and interpreted. Review information is shown to be related to customer satisfaction and their trust and intentions (Camilleri and Filieri, 2023). Thus, the reviews may not be simply promotional; they should be analysed as inputs to decisions.

## 1.2 Research Context and Problem

Consumer-generated information is positioned in the sideways of the booking environments with the price, location, and description of the hotel (Mellinas et al., 2025). However, there can be a negative star rating when a positive average rating is present, and when content is manipulated or automated, it may be difficult to trust the rating (Camilleri and Filieri, 2023). The research on platform scoring has shown that the platform scores are not necessarily comparable (Leoni and Boto-García, 2023).

## 1.3 Research Aim and Objectives

This research aims to explore the effect of online customer reviews on UK customers' hotel booking intention.

Objectives crafted to achieve the research aim are:

- To evaluate the significance of positive and negative comments, star ratings, credibility and authenticity
- To explore the link between review information and trust; and examine the impact of these factors on booking intent.
- To suggest strategies and tactics to enhance the intention of UK customer’s through effective online customer reviews.

## 1.4 Research Question

The research question is:

- *To what extent do review valence, star ratings, perceived credibility and perceived authenticity predict hotel booking intention among UK consumers, and how does trust contribute to these relationships?*

# 2. Background and Context

## 2.1 Online Customer Reviews in the Hotel Industry

Services at the hotel are hard to assess in advance, and the experiences of other guests may be relevant when choosing a hotel (Xu et al., 2025). Online ratings provide a sense of cleanliness, staff responsiveness, location and value, and star ratings provide a simple comparative cue. But the positive and negative information can produce different effects, and negative information can be more attention-drawing if it is longer in duration and describes specific risks (Pooja and Upadhyaya, 2025; Hernández-Maestro, 2025). The perceived usefulness of a review also relies on its credibility, user identification and accompanying pictures (An, Ozturk and Okumus, 2025). Consumer interpretations are therefore not uniform but rather are based on average scores. In addition, if a review is found to be fake, it could impact the credibility of the review platform as a whole and of the specific hotel (Zaman et al., 2024).

### 2.2 The Role of Online Travel Platforms

Online travel agencies like Booking.com, Expedia and Tripadvisor structure hotel data in listings, which bundle the hotel cost, availability, client reviews and scores (Xu et al., 2025). The order and display of information can influence attention and perception of quality, while their interfaces can lower search costs. Review tags enable users to find experiences, and the automatic summarisation gives another layer of interpretation (Jia, Chi and Chi, 2025). Platform scoring adds another layer of complexity, as apparent ratings can vary from underlying scores, and the weight of the most recent reviews can influence the rating a hotel shows (Leoni and Boto-García, 2023; Mellinas et al., 2025). As a result, their reactions to the review can also be directed at the platform in which the review is presented (Chan et al., 2025).

### 2.3 Importance of Online Reviews in the UK Hotel Market

VisitBritain (2026) states that in England the number of domestic overnight trips is to be 87 million in 2025, of which 40% are in hotels. These are not a representation of bookings for tourism, but they show tourism activity and the market in which online information can have an impact when compared with accommodation. More than half of adults in the UK use online reviews (CMA, 2025), and the Competition and Markets Authority (CMA) has provided guidance on fabricated or misleading reviews. By focusing on this regulatory attention, this economic value of reliable information for consumers is brought to the fore. However, the impact of ratings, review sentiment and authenticity cannot be determined in relation to the UK as traveller profiles and platforms may vary (Singh and Mittal, 2026)

## 3. Critical Literature Review

### 3.1 Influence of Positive and Negative Online Reviews

The online customer review system affects hotel reviews because it provides information regarding previous guests' experiences (Singh and Mittal, 2026). Positive reviews can increase

booking and recommendation intentions, whilst negative reviews can discourage potential customers by highlighting possible service problems. El-Said (2020), examining hotel booking intention, found that negative reviews had a stronger influence than positive reviews, with effects moderated by brand image, hotel category, and price. Likewise, Syafganti and Walrave (2022) showed that positive reviews led to an increase in booking and recommendation intentions through an experiment. These results indicate that the valence of the review is a factor, and that it has different effects in different contexts of decision making.

Feng et al. (2022) conducted an ERP experiment to study online hotel booking decisions. Positive reviews resulted in higher booking rates than negative reviews, and negative reviews evoked greater neural responses related to emotional conflict. This method gives some idea of how decisions are made, but experiments can be used with stimuli that are not as complex as real situations. Shukla and Mishra (2023) revealed that the valence of the reviews had a positive impact on the perceived credibility and subsequently the booking intent. Contrary to what is often thought; however, the length of the review was not significant, suggesting that longer reviews do not necessarily lead to more persuasive reviews.

El-Said, Elhoushy and Al Bulushi (2024) also discovered that the customer's own visual content, such as photos, interacted with written review valence in forecasting booking intention, indicating that photos can influence consumer perceptions of review content. More direct behavioural evidence is provided by Cho et al. (2024), who looked at real hotel bookings in six U.S. markets. They found that a hotel's own reviews and competitor reviews both had an impact on demand. This is stronger evidence of market behaviour than stated intention, although the US context limits direct generalisation to the UK.

### 3.2 Impact of Star Ratings on Hotel Booking Decisions

Hotel comparisons are streamlined with the use of star ratings, which are a summary of previous customers' evaluations. However, ratings alone do not give a numerical explanation for customer satisfaction or dissatisfaction, and consumers might use ratings in addition to written feedback, the price, and the reputation of the brand. Wen et al. (2021) conducted experiments to investigate the relationship between online reviews, hotel brand, and price. Their work highlights that review information does not operate independently: consumers evaluate it alongside other signals of expected quality. Similarly, Jiang et al. (2024) combined real-world secondary data with survey evidence and found that differences in hotel ratings and review-related information could positively affect sales. This indicates that the consumers'

reaction is influenced not only by the highest rating but also by the differences in the availability of signals.

An and Ozturk (2022) explored both customer-generated photos and review valence. They found that both visual information and the sentiment of the review affected the perception of hotel price, service quality, image, and the likelihood of booking. Therefore, ratings should be backed up by a detailed and credible description or photograph to be more convincing. Cho et al. (2024) confirm this point by showing that sentiment in reviews influences actual booking performance, and that competitor reviews also influence performance. However, the effect varies across customer groups and review content, challenging the assumption that ratings have an identical influence on every traveller.

### 3.3 Review Credibility and Consumer Trust

Review credibility refers to whether consumers believe the feedback that is displayed online is credible and reliable. The significance of it in the hospitality industry is that customers are not able to try a hotel's service prior to booking. Chakraborty (2019) examined source, receiver, and message factors affecting perceived review credibility and hotel booking intention. The study points out that a positive or negative review is not the most important factor in determining credibility, as the characteristics of the message and the message's source are also important. Furthermore, Güler and Huseynov (2021) examined consumer reviews of hotels on the internet and intention to book a hotel by analysing the data by confirmatory factor analysis and structural equation modelling. They found that the volume of the reviews and their credibility had a significant impact on booking intention, whilst the other factors that they examined did not have a significant impact on perceived credibility. They have shown that some of the factors considered to be reliable indicators of reviews may not be as consistent.

Similarly, Shukla and Mishra (2023) found that review valence significantly influenced perceived credibility, whereas review length had no significant effect. They found that there is no evidence that detailed or lengthy reviews are more trusted. However, questionnaire-based studies rely on reported perceptions and intentions, which may differ from actual booking behaviour. Pooja and Upadhyaya (2024) have compiled research on the credibility of online reviews and found that there are several factors that can affect a person's judgment of the credibility of an online review. Though the review is not as detailed as an individual survey, its findings apply to online reviews of products and services, and not just hotel bookings. Moliner-Velázquez, Fuentes-Blasco and Gil-Saura (2023) found that perceived credibility and confirmation of consulted electronic word-of-mouth were associated with attitudes towards this

information, in their study of 393 Spanish hotel guests. This reinforces the importance of credibility from the review reader's point of view, but the same relationships can be drawn between UK consumers and this Spanish sample.

### 3.4 Electronic Word-of-Mouth (eWOM) and Booking Behaviour

Electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) is defined as consumer opinions and experiences communicated electronically. In the hotel booking, it helps prospective guests to learn from previous customers and not depend only on hotel marketing. However, the usefulness of eWOM depends on its credibility, content, and relevance to the consumer. Kumari and Sangeetha (2022) analysed the positive eWOM and green hotel booking intention with 223 survey responses. Their findings identified argument quality, source credibility, review valence, and consumer ratings as important factors. This confirms the relevance of eWOM, but due to the focus on green hotels, results might not be equally applicable to all types of accommodation. Furthermore, Moliner-Velázquez et al. (2023) studied the motivations and attitudes of 393 visitors of Spanish hotels for consulting eWOM. The findings from their research emphasised the importance of credibility and confirmation of consulted information. This study goes beyond just analysing whether consumers are likely to book; it also helps explain why consumers read reviews and how they analyse the information.

Salameh et al. (2022), using 884 valid survey responses, found that review usefulness and quantity were positively associated with use of online hotel booking platforms. However, platform usage is not equivalent to choosing a hotel or completing a reservation. Cho et al. (2024) offer more compelling behavioural evidence, for they analysed real booking data and accounted for the impact of competitor reviews.

### 3.5 Fake Reviews and Consumer Uncertainty

Fake reviews can make online hotel information less reliable, as it could be deemed to be false customer reviews. This leaves customers wary of making assumptions about the level of service they will receive from a new business. Zaman et al. (2024) looked at the attitude of British, French and Italian tourists towards writing fake online reviews. Their participation in the UK is significant, but they looked at the creation of fake reviews, not at how consumers react when they are confronted with fake reviews when they book a hotel. Its conclusions are therefore unable to conclude, on their own, the impact of dishonest reviews on UK bookings. Reyes-Menendez et al. (2019) conducted a systematic review of research on fake reviews in tourism businesses. They found that technical detection methods such as algorithmic detection

and sentiment-based detection were important, and other methods were less frequently used. This moves beyond consumer psychology to the issue of how to recognise shady information. However, detecting suspicious patterns does not necessarily reveal whether individual consumers recognise them.

Pooja and Upadhyaya (2024) conducted a study on the factors influencing the credibility of online reviews. Their findings provide some insight into why consumers may rely on source elements and review information to gauge the trustworthiness of a books site; however, credibility research is not direct evidence of the ability to detect fake reviews in hotel bookings. Similarly, Shukla and Mishra (2023) established that booking intention is related to perceived credibility, which explains the significance of misleading reviews. However, this does not actually mean that false reviews affect completed bookings.

### 3.6 Critical Comparison of Existing Studies and Research Findings

There is mixed research on the effect of online reviews on hotel ratings and experiences when booking hotels. Survey studies, such as Shukla and Mishra (2023), Salameh et al. (2022), and Moliner-Velázquez et al. (2023) provide evidence of consumer perceptions and self-reported behaviour. However, cross-sectional questionnaires cannot establish causality, and stated booking intentions do not necessarily translate into actual hotel reservations.

Experimental studies, such as the work conducted by Syafganti and Walrave (2022), Feng et al. (2022) and An and Ozturk (2022), enable researchers to compare the responses to the controlled setting of the research. But experimental scenarios may make real-life booking decisions easier. Cho et al. (2024), however, employed real booking data, which enhanced the behavioural relevance of the study, albeit at an expense of the international audience of their study being the US. Hernández-Maestro (2025) examines 19,441 negative reviews of 121 Spanish hotels from a specific platform, market, and review valence, providing significant observational evidence.

The studies also examine various outcomes such as credibility, platform use, booking intent and sales. These measures are related but not synonymous. Additionally, many of the sources have been external to the UK, and there has been no direct research in the UK that proves the impact of authenticity on the decision to book. The primary limitation is the lack of integrated evidence with regard to consumer interpretations of review valence, ratings, credibility and authenticity as they choose hotels in the UK.

### 3.7 Research Gap

It is argued in literature that the review sentiment, star ratings and credibility may influence the selection of a hotel; however, it is unclear what the impact of these factors is. The actual demand for a particular country is reflected in the overseas hotel markets, while the booking intention is reflected by the questionnaire studies (Chan et al., 2025; Saha and Biswas, 2025). These results should not be considered comparable. This is because the ratings are calculated on the platform and do not provide a fair and overall picture of experiences (Leoni and Boto-García, 2023; Mellinas et al., 2025).

A second gap is with regard to authenticity. Researchers, such as Zaman et al. (2024) and Singh and Mittal (2026), have found incentives for fabricated reviews, and recent studies have linked authenticity and awareness of AI to trust. The results of samples not collected in the UK, however, cannot necessarily be used to fully explain consumers in the unique travel market and regulatory environment of the UK (CMA, 2025; Murray, 2026; VisitBritain, 2026). This study therefore takes a holistic perspective and examines these three factors in tandem, reviews them, and considers them as predictors of trust and hotel booking intention with the understanding that a survey is not a true reflection of actual purchases but an indication of what consumers desire.

## 4. Theoretical and Conceptual Framework

### 4.1 Theoretical Framework

This study will be based on the stimulus–organism–response (S–O–R) theory by Mehrabian and Russell (1974), which focuses on the role of the environment in determining the internal evaluation before affecting the behaviour. Valence, star ratings, credibility and authenticity will be stimuli for online hotel booking (Mellinas et al., 2025). These cues will be interpreted by the consumer, leading to a formation of different levels of trust and ultimately the intention to book. The sequence is based on recent studies conducted by hotel researchers on the relationship between electronic word of mouth (EWOM) and trust and hotel reservation intention (Saha and Biswas, 2025; Praphasiri, Lekcharoen and Pankham, 2026).

One strength of S–O–R is that it allows for several review features to be linked to one another by a common psychological mechanism instead of rating just being individual predictors. It also allows for assessment of trust as a mediator, which can help to explain the differences in intentions that can result from the same information (Leoni and Boto-García, 2023). However, the framework can be simplistic in nature, suggesting a uniform sequence and ignoring algorithms used on platforms, habits, prices and the reason for travelling. The findings of a cross-sectional survey will also not be able to determine if trust comes before intention (Jia, Chi and Chi, 2025). Furthermore, ratings and reviews can be different, as platforms calculate

ratings in a different way (Leoni and Boto-García, 2023). These weaknesses will need to be controlled and interpreted with caution.

In the UK context the theory suggests that far more than raising visibility of ratings, it is enhancing the credibility of reviews that can be of importance for hotel managers. Anomalies of the signal could alter its interpretation, as could negative comments or images submitted by users (Pooja and Upadhyaya, 2025; An et al., 2025). However, these implications will be propositions until they are trialled with consumers in the UK.

### 4.2 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework will be used to operationalise S–O–R to measurable variables. Theindependent variables (IVs) will be the review valence, star ratings, perceived credibility and perceived authenticity. Perceived trust will be used as the mediating variable (MV), and the dependent variable (DV) is hotel booking intention. The framework will make indirect comparisons based on trust and suggest possible direct connections between review features and booking intent. These relationships align with the findings that there is evidence of the effect of credibility and authenticity on consumer dependence on the reviews (Camilleri and Filieri, 2023; Singh and Mittal, 2026). Control variables (CVs) will include age, previous frequency of online hotel booking, and the hotel booking platform in use, as these factors could affect trust and/or intention apart from the impact of the review content. The four predictors of the focal model are clearly identified from the figure below as the controls. The ability to account for part of the relationships in terms of perceived trust will be tested through statistical analysis, but causal relationships will not be confirmed based on measured relationships.

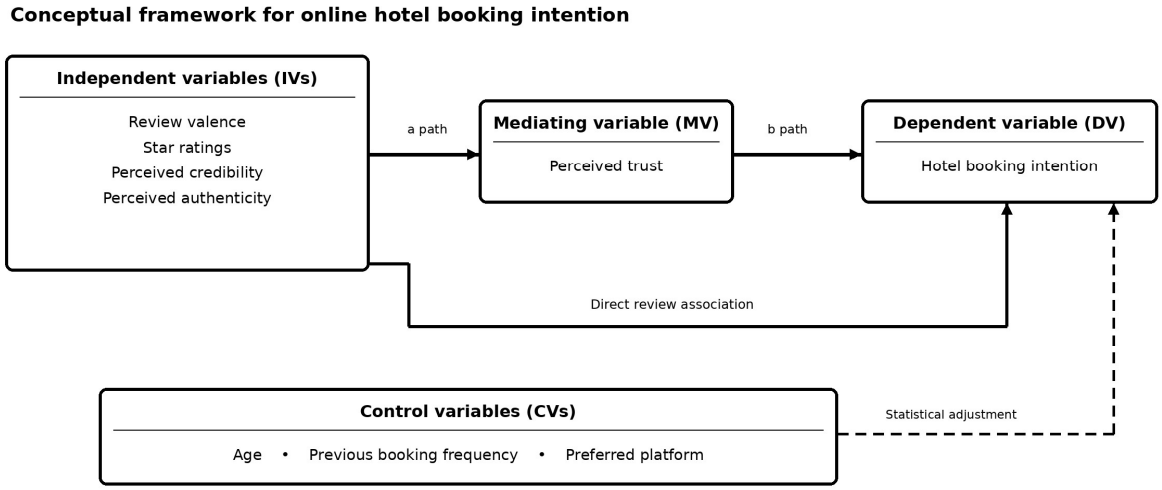



**Figure 1 Conceptual Framework**

## 5. Methodology

### 5.1 Research Philosophy

The research will be rely on the post-positivist philosophy. It will take the position that consumer attitudes can be investigated with observable cues but that what consumers say about their perceptions is never going to be precise enough to predict behavior. This role will involve systematic measurements, statistical testing and careful interpretation. A purely interpretivist position would yield richer individual meaning but would not be appropriate for comparing the relative power of several predictors from one respondent to another (Creswell and Plano Clark, 2025). Researcher assumptions via positivism will be effective in making clear decisions in the wording, sampling and analysis.

### 5.2 Research Approach

A deductive approach will be used for this study. Propositions bridging review features and trust and booking intention will be developed based on the literature review and conceptual framework. The propositions will then be translated into measurable items of the survey and will be analysed statistically. An inductive approach would involve letting themes develop from interviews but would not be a good way to test the relationships that were proposed (Creswell and Creswell, 2023). The research will thus start with existing ideas, gather structured evidence and then evaluate whether the associations observed will support the ideas.

### 5.3 Methodological choice and critical evaluation.

A quantitative method will be chosen because similar numerical responses will allow for the estimation of relationships and the evaluation of alternative explanations (Fink, 2024). Standardised measures will increase consistency, but closed questions will limit any unexpected findings and lead to a more limited degree of decision-making. A qualitative methodology through semi-structured interviews would reveal the ways in which individuals deal with conflicting comments or possible bogus reviews. It would provide minimal statistical comparison; however, a smaller sample of interviews would provide better insight (Flink, 2025). A mixed-methods design would bring in some breadth along with some depth and might account for some surprising statistical findings. More recruitment, transcription and integration, however, would be outside the scope of the project available resources. The quantitative choice will thus yield the best match with the explanation research question.

### 5.4 Research Strategy and Time Horizon

A cross-sectional, online questionnaire will be used for investigation. Data will only be gathered once, which will enable perceptions of the review information and booking intentions to be compared for the same timeframe. This will be possible via online delivery, which will enable participation across the UK at a low cost. An experimental design with manipulated

ratings, and with review sentiment manipulated, would offer better evidence of causal influence but it may create artificial booking situations (Ford and Scandura, 2023). A longitudinal design would confirm the change in attitudes better but would involve repeated recruitment. Thus, the design that is chosen will be used to estimate associations and not to show cause and effect.

**5.5 Data Collection Instrument**

The questionnaire will include the consent and screening items, booking frequency, and platform preference items. Moreover, review valence, the need for star ratings, perceived credibility, authenticity, trust and booking intention will be measured using five-point Likert scales (Saunders et al. 2023). There will be a number of items with clearly-formulated content for each central construct. The participants will be asked to remember the most recent time they looked up a hotel so that the answers will be similar. A pilot with several (10) eligible adults will test the clarity of the questions, mobile accessibility of the questions, and question order and time to complete. Feedback will be used to make revisions prior to full distribution.

**5.6 Population and Sampling**

The target market will consist of people aged 18 or above who have looked for or thought about booking a hotel on the Internet in the past year in the UK. Questions will be screened to determine eligibility. Around 250 full answers will be invited from various travel networks, social media and university connections. To enhance diversity, purposive recruitment will be used with wide age and UK region quotas (Hooley, 2024). The non-probability sample, however, will not be representative of all UK travellers, with frequent internet users and travel interest groups possibly being over-represented.

A power analysis will be conducted prior to distribution to determine if the proposed number of predictors for a planned sample will provide the necessary power. When the number of recruits is small, the analysis will focus on a smaller number of variables but in a theoretically appropriate way, rather than fit a model (Omeihe and Harrison, 2024). All exclusions and analysis decisions will be reported for reproduction, and results will distinguish between statistical significance and practical significance.

**5.7 Data Analysis**

Responses will be transferred to SPSS and examined for missing, duplicate, ineligible responses and abnormally fast responses. Analytical data will be summarised using descriptive statistics that will present the characteristics of respondents and patterns of respondents' reviews. The internal consistency will be evaluated by Cronbach's alpha, and initial relationships will be evaluated by correlations (Field, 2024). Multiple regression will be used to estimate the individual contribution of each review attribute to the dependent variable of

booking intention, while accounting for the effects of other factors that are potentially associated with booking intention, such as age and booking frequency (Creswell and Plano Clark, 2025). A bootstrapped indirect-effects procedure will examine whether this relationship between trust and the two will be statistically mediated. Along with significance tests, effect sizes, confidence intervals and assumption checks will be provided. Caution will be exercised when interpreting, as cross-sectional relationships will not prove causal.

### 5.8 Evaluation

3

The current evidence has confirmed the impact of online reviews on the decision to book a hotel, but it provides an incomplete account of how consumers respond to the conflicting cues provided by websites when booking. However, studies focus on ratings, credibility and trust, and the differences in scoring on platforms make comparisons of numerical indicators less reliable (Leoni and Boto-García, 2023; Mellinas et al., 2025). It is also not possible to show purchasing behaviour through research on intended bookings (Saha and Biswas, 2025). Importantly, international findings may not mirror the expectation and/or exposure of UK travellers to misleading reviews. The following analysis should thus focus on review valence, review authenticity and review trust and should be conducted in a context of the UK, without relying on causal claims and with an awareness and sensitivity to sampling limitations.

## 6. Conclusion

The findings indicate that besides positive reviews or top ratings, information on hotel books is influenced by other factors such as credibility, authenticity and trust. However, samples from overseas, differences in platform scores and the often reliance on intended, not finished, bookings limit transferability to the UK. The proposed S–O–R model incorporates these dimensions and defines testable relationships. A qualitative online survey would not be appropriate for comparing the relative association of their relationship between the UK respondents. Selection bias, self-reporting, and not being able to draw inferences of causation are acknowledged; however, a deductive, quantitative online survey would be appropriate. If results are reported within those methodological boundaries, the findings can be used to support the transparency of the presentation of reviews both on hotels and on booking platforms and consumer confidence.

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